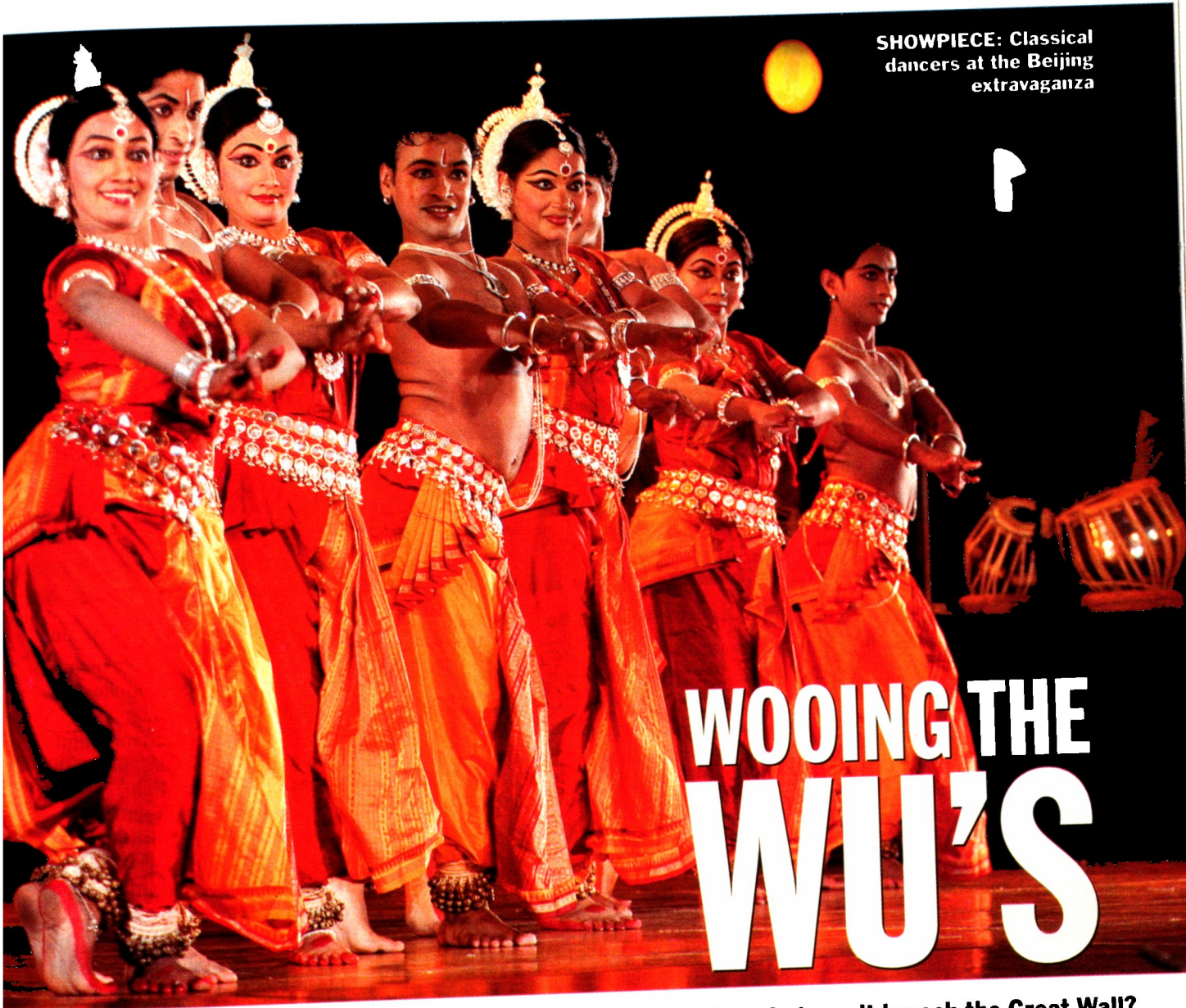


SHOWPIECE: Classical dancers at the Beijing extravaganza



WOOING THE WU'S

India targets Chinese tourists with its Incredible India roadshow, but can it breach the Great Wall?

■ **By Dilip Bobb in Beijing/Shanghai**

Travelling from Shanghai to Delhi on China Eastern Airlines can be painful. TV programmes and in-flight magazines are in Chinese and they only serve cheap table wine. On a morning flight, you will get breakfast that consists mainly of a plastic bowl of bland, sticky rice porridge. It's a pretty unappetising way to start a discovery of India but the Chinese passengers slurp it down like it's Beluga caviar. The airline, one of China's largest, clearly caters to its local clientele. There's only one problem: 90 per cent of the seats are occupied by Indians and the sprinkling of Chinese

passengers is symbolic of the fact that the grass is still greener on their side of the other Great Wall, the Himalayas.

Last year, which was officially India-China Friendship Year Through Tourism, 4,62,450 Indians visited China while the reverse traffic was just over 62,000. There is, however, a Chinese proverb that says: "A journey of a thousand miles begins with a single step." That step was taken last week as Delhi launched a cultural-culinary blitzkrieg orchestrated by the Ministry of Tourism. The roadshow had targeted Berlin and New York in 2007 but breaching the Great Wall was its sternest test. The Chinese may be opening up to the world but they are

still extremely, obsessively, insular.

For most Chinese, India is symbolised by four dominant images: IT, the Dalai Lama, Raj Kapoor and spicy food, which they relish, judging by the number of Indian restaurants. Those images are now considerably enhanced, thanks to a spectacular, superbly choreographed cultural extravaganza in Beijing and Shanghai.

Minister for Tourism Ambika Soni is sophisticated enough to have kept the Incredible India campaign free of any bureaucratic heavy-handedness. Instead, she left it to professionals to give the events international appeal. Kabir Bedi was master of ceremonies while the dance performance was